

AN UNEXPECTED CROSS

TEXT: Matthew 27:27-32 (KJV) *“Then the soldiers of the governor took Jesus into the common hall, and gathered unto him the whole band of soldiers. ²⁸And they stripped him, and put on him a scarlet robe. ²⁹And when they had platted a crown of thorns, they put it upon his head, and a reed in his right hand: and they bowed the knee before him, and mocked him, saying, Hail, King of the Jews! ³⁰And they spit upon him, and took the reed, and smote him on the head. ³¹And after that they had mocked him, they took the robe off from him, and put his own raiment on him, and led him away to crucify him. ³²And as they came out, they found a man of Cyrene, Simon by name: him they compelled to bear his cross.”*

INTRO: The word compelled here comes from the Greek word Aggareuo (Uh-gar-e-o)

and means “*To employ a courier, dispatch a mounted messenger, press into public service.*” In this Scripture it is not clear whether Simon was forced, encouraged, or volunteered to carry the cross of Jesus. On the surface it appears he was selected and not given a choice.

There are nine men named Simon in the New Testament:

- Simon Peter, the Disciple of Jesus
- Simon, who was called Zelotes
- Simon, the father of Judas, who betrayed Jesus
- Simon, the Samaritan wizard
- Simon, the tanner
- Simon, the Pharisee
- Simon, the cousin of Jesus
- Simon, the leper
- Simon of Cyrene, who carried the cross of Jesus

I suppose we could talk about any one of these men and find some pretty interesting things about their lives. This man Simon who carried the cross of Jesus is a particularly interesting character. We know very little about him. In fact, the only thing we know for sure is that he was called upon to carry an unexpected cross.

It was probably out of curiosity that Simon attended the kangaroo court that sentenced Jesus to death. He was an innocent bystander who was called upon to do something he was not expecting to do. He probably did not get up that morning to attend the hearing of Jesus in hopes of carrying his cross to Golgotha. Most of us have better things to do than volunteer to carry a ninety-pound cross up a mountainside.

Most of us either have faced unexpected crosses or will face unexpected crosses. An

unexpected cross is being forced to deal with something we did not see coming. (I didn't start it raining)

Certainly, there are things we can see while they are still at a distance, and in such a scenario, we can make preparations to deal with them in an orderly fashion. Other things take us by surprise and we are forced to deal with them on a moment-to-moment basis.

Some areas we face unexpected crosses:

I. UNEXPECTED CROSSES WITHIN RELATIONSHIPS

A family possesses the ability to bring the greatest joy into our lives and they can also bring the most bitter disappointment:

- Marriage – Psalms 68:5 (NKJV) Say's He will be "*A defender of the widows.*"
- Children – Proverbs 22:6 (NKJV) "*Train up a child in the way he should*

go, And when he is old he will not depart from it.”

- Absentee Parents – Psalms 68:5 (NKJV) He will be a *“Father to the fatherless.”* Psalms 27:10 (NKJV) *“When my father and my mother forsake me, Then the LORD will take care of me.”*
- Broken Friendships – Hebrews 13:5-6 (KJV) *“Let your conduct be without covetousness; be content with such things as you have. For He Himself has said, “I will never leave you nor forsake you.”* ⁶*So we may boldly say: “The LORD is my helper; I will not fear. What can man do to me?”* Romans 8:31 (KJV) *“What shall we then say to these things? If God be for us, who can be against us?”*

II. UNEXPECTED CROSSES WITH OUR HEALTH

When we are healthy, we take our health for granted. None of us ever plan to be sick, but

sickness is in the world and all of us will be called upon to deal with it sooner or later.

ILLUSTRATION: (Cardiologist 2001)

Let me remind you today that the Doctor does not have the final word. God will have the final say!

SONG: *“Whose report will you believe? I shall believe the report of the Lord!”*

Looking forward to the time of Christ the Prophet Isaiah made this declarative statement. Isaiah 53:5 (NKJV) ***“But He was wounded for our transgressions, He was bruised for our iniquities; The chastisement for our peace was upon Him, And by His stripes we are healed.”***

Looking back on the events surrounding the crucifixion of Christ the apostle Peter made

this observation. 1 Peter 2:24 (NKJV)
“Who Himself bore our sins in His own body on the tree, that we, having died to sins, might live for righteousness—by whose stripes you were healed.”

III. UNEXPECTED CROSSES WITHIN OUR FINANCES

Oftentimes as we are making our way through life, unexpected financial pressure and reversals can hit us. These unexpected crosses can come through many avenues:

- Budget-breaking circumstances – Psalms 37:23-25 (NKJV) *“The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD, And He delights in his way. ²⁴ Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand. ²⁵ I have been young, and now am old; Yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, Nor his descendants begging bread.”*

- Employment changes – Philippians 4:19 (CEV) *“And this same God who takes care of me will supply all your needs from his glorious riches, which have been given to us in Christ Jesus.”*
- Investment reversals – Job 13:15 (NKJV) *“Though He slay me, yet will I trust Him.”* Job was given double for his trouble and lived twice as long after the trial than he did before the trial.

Add to these things inflation and taxes and you have a prescription for disaster.

Someone sent me an e-mail that said... *“Tax his land, tax his bed, tax the table at which he's fed! Tax his tractor, tax his mule, teach him taxes are the rule! Tax his work, tax his pay he works for peanuts anyway! Tax his cow, tax his goat, tax his pants, and tax his coat! Tax his ties, tax his shirt and don't stop there, tax his dirt! Tax his food, tax his drink, tax him if he tries to think! Tax his car, tax his gas, tax his wife, tax his heirs,*

*and if he cries tax his tears! Tax all he has,
then let him know that you won't be done till
he has no more dough! When he screams
and hollers tax him some more, tax him till
he's good and sore! Tax his coffin, tax his
grave, tax the sod in which he's laid! When
he's dead put these words upon his tomb,
"Taxes drove him to his doom!" When he's
gone, do not relax, its time to apply the
inheritance tax!"*

*There's more! "Accounts receivable tax;
building permit tax; CDL license tax;
cigarette tax; corporate income tax; dog
license tax; excise tax; federal income tax;
federal unemployment tax; fishing license
tax; food license tax; fuel permit tax;
gasoline tax (42 cents per gallon); gross
receipts tax; hunting license tax; inheritance
tax; inventory tax; IRS interest charges; IRS
penalties (tax on top of tax); luxury tax;
marriage license tax; medi-care tax;
personal property tax; real estate tax;*

service charge tax; social security tax; road usage tax; sales tax; recreational vehicle tax; school tax; state income tax; state unemployment tax; telephone federal excise tax; telephone federal universal service fee tax; telephone federal, state and local surcharge tax; telephone minimum usage surcharge tax; telephone recurring and non-recurring charges tax; utility tax; vehicle license registration tax; watercraft registration tax; well permit tax; workers compensation tax!”

Guess what? Not one of these taxes existed one hundred years ago, and our nation was the most prosperous in the world. We had absolutely no national debt; the largest middle class in the world; and Mom stayed home to raise the kids! What in the world happened? POLITICIANS!

In the midst of all of this I stand to proclaim,
“*Our source is the Lord!*” Luke 12:22-31

(NKJV) *“Therefore I say to you, do not worry about your life, what you will eat; nor about the body, what you will put on.*
²³*“Life is more than food, and the body is more than clothing.* ²⁴*“Consider the ravens, for they neither sow nor reap, which have neither storehouse nor barn; and God feeds them. Of how much more value are you than the birds?* ²⁵*“And which of you by worrying can add one cubit to his stature?*
²⁶*“If you then are not able to do the least, why are you anxious for the rest?*
²⁷*“Consider the lilies, how they grow: they neither toil nor spin; and yet I say to you, even Solomon in all his glory was not arrayed like one of these.* ²⁸*“If then God so clothes the grass, which today is in the field and tomorrow is thrown into the oven, how much more will He clothe you, O you of little faith?* ²⁹*“And do not seek what you should eat or what you should drink, nor have an anxious mind.* ³⁰*“For all these things the nations of the world seek after,*

and your Father knows that you need these things. ³¹*“But seek the kingdom of God,*
and all these things shall be added to you.”

Psalms 37:23-25 (NKJV) *“The steps of
a good man are ordered by the LORD,
And He delights in his way. ²⁴ Though
he fall, he shall not be utterly cast
down; For the LORD upholds him with
His hand. ²⁵ I have been young, and
now am old; Yet I have not seen the
righteous forsaken, Nor his
descendants begging bread.”*

Philippians 4:19 (NKJV) *“My God shall
supply all your need according to His
riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”*

CONCLUSION: Simon had no way of knowing what he would face on the day Jesus was crucified. He was not aware of the fact he would be called upon to climb a mountain with a ninety-pound cross on his

back, but don't you know that God stepped in and gave him super-human strength?

2 Corinthians 12:6-10 (NKJV) ***“For though I might desire to boast, I will not be a fool; for I will speak the truth. But I refrain, lest anyone should think of me above what he sees me to be or hears from me. ⁷And lest I should be exalted above measure by the abundance of the revelations, a thorn in the flesh was given to me, a messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I be exalted above measure. ⁸Concerning this thing I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might depart from me. ⁹And He said to me, “My grace is sufficient for you, for My strength is made perfect in weakness.” Therefore most gladly I will rather boast in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. ¹⁰Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities, in reproaches, in needs, in persecutions, in distresses, for Christ’s***

sake. For when I am weak, then I am strong.”

God will never allow you to fight this battle alone.